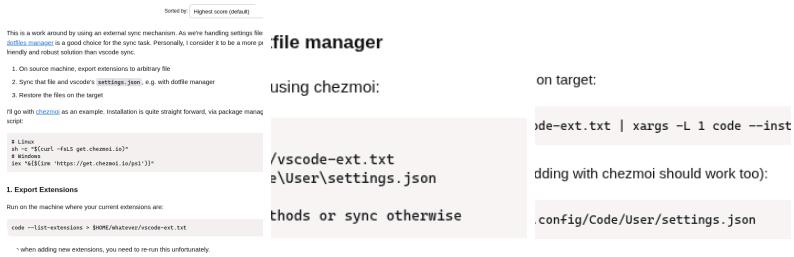

Sorted by: Highest score (default)

This is a work around by using an external sync mechanism. As we're handling settings file dotfiles manager is a good choice for the sync task. Personally, I consider it to be a more pr friendly and robust solution than vscode sync.

1. On source machine, export extensions to arbitrary file
2. Sync that file and vscode's `settings.json`, e.g. with dotfile manager
3. Restore the files on the target

I'll go with chezmoi as an example. Installation is quite straight forward, via package manag script:

```
# Linux
sh -c "$(curl -fsLS get.chezmoi.io)"
# Windows
iex "&{$(iim 'https://get.chezmoi.io/ps1')}"
```

1. Export Extensions

Run on the machine where your current extensions are:

```
code --list-extensions > $HOME/whatever/vscode-ext.txt
```

when adding new extensions, you need to re-run this unfortunately.

file manager

using chezmoi:

```
/vscode-ext.txt
e\User\settings.json

thods or sync otherwise
```

on target:

```
ode-ext.txt | xargs -L 1 code --inst
```

dding with chezmoi should work too):

```
.config/Code/User/settings.json
```

1 year ago I made this SO post: https://stackoverflow.com/questions/79459007/vs-code-settings-sync-not-restoring-anything-on-linux

I got only 1 solution (a workaround with chezmoi). I attached the solution as images.

However, while this does somewhat work, when it reinstalls my extensions, it also keeps everything enabled. There are a lot of extensions I have (like vim) that I have disabled temporarily or that i disable until I feel like using them, or because I believe they may be causing errors and I have yet to confirm, etc. Whatever the case, is there a way I can also backup & restore the "Disabled" (basically, keep what was disabled previoiusly disabled, rather than installing them and leaving them enabled). So when I restore vim extension for example, I want to keep the extension's settings and everything, but keep it disabled if it was previously disabled.

Yes — VS Code actually **stores which extensions are disabled**, but the workaround you used only backs up:

- the **extension list** (`code --list-extensions`)
- **settings.json**

It does **not back up VS Code's internal extension state**, which is where the *enabled/disabled* flags live. So when you reinstall extensions via CLI, VS Code assumes

they should all be **enabled**.

The trick is to also back up the **extension state database**.

Where VS Code stores enabled/disabled extensions

On Linux it's stored here:

```
~/.config/Code/User/globalStorage/state.vscdb
```

This is a **SQLite database** containing UI state, including:

- extension enable/disable status
- some workspace state
- misc VS Code UI flags

So if you copy this file along with your other configs, the disabled extensions will be restored too.

Updated Backup Strategy

1. Export extensions (same as before)

Bash

---

2. Back up VS Code state + settings

Add these files to your dotfile manager:

```
~/.config/Code/User/settings.json
~/.config/Code/User/globalStorage/state.vscdb
```

With **chezmoi**, for example:

```
chezmoi add ~/.config/Code/User/settings.json
```

Bash

Commit/push as usual.

Restore Process

1. Install extensions

Bash

---

2. Restore settings + state

Bash

Restart VS Code.

Your extensions that were previously disabled should remain **disabled**.

Important caveat

This only works reliably if:

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- You restore **before opening VS Code the first time**

Otherwise VS Code may overwrite the state database.

Alternative (more precise approach)

Instead of copying the entire state DB, you can export **only disabled extensions**:

```bash
code --list-extensions --show-versions
```

Then detect disabled ones from:

```
~/.config/Code/User/globalStorage/state.vscdb
```

But that requires SQLite parsing and is more complicated than simply syncing the DB.

✅ **Best practical solution:**
Backup `state.vscdb` **+ extensions list + settings.json`**.

💡 If you want, I can also show you a **cleaner VS Code backup script (10–15 lines)** that automatically backs up:

- extensions
- disabled extensions
- settings
- keybindings
- snippets

and restores them perfectly on a new machine.